Beyond Boundaries: Unleashing the Power of Ideas through Collaborative Improvement and Innovation

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To holon ti para ta moria estin
"The whole is something beyond the parts"
Aristotle

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Louise Östberg

Funäsdalen, November 2026

Table of contents

List of terms and definitions ..... **xi**

Abstract ..... **xiii**

Summary in Swedish ..... **xv**

List of appended papers ..... **xvii**

Preface ..... **xix**

1 Introduction **1**

1.1 Background 1

1.2 Purpose and research questions 5

1.3 Connection between Research Questions and Papers 6

2 Theoretical frame of reference **8**

2.1 Continuous improvement and innovation as a part of Quality Management 8

2.2 Collaboration across boundaries in inter-organisational contexts 10

2.3 Collaborative improvement 13

2.4 Idea generation and development in collaborative settings 16

2.5 Co-creation in collaborative improvement 19

3 Research Methodology **21**

3.1 Philosophical worldview 21

3.2 Researcher experiences and pre-understanding 25

3.3 Research approach 26

3.4 Research design and methods 27

3.4.1 Study 1 (Paper A) – Systematic Literature Review 29

3.4.2 Study 2 (Paper B) – Collaborative Improvement in Rural Ecosystems (LUP Study) 31

3.4.3 Study 3 (Paper C) – Inter-organisational experiential exchanges (SUB-study) 33

3.5 Ethical considerations 35

3.6 Quality criteria - Rigour, trustworthiness and Reflexivity 36

3.6.1 Quality criteria for Study 1 (Paper A): Systematic Literature Review 37

3.6.2 Quality criteria for Study 2 (Paper B): Collaborative improvement in rural ecosystems (LUP-study) 38

3.6.3 Quality criteria for Study 3 (Paper C): Inter-organisational experiential exchanges (SUB-study) 39

4 Summary of appended papers 41

4.1 Summary of Paper A 42

4.2 Summary of Paper B 45

4.3 Summary of Paper C 48

5 Main findings 51

5.1 Findings related to Research Question 1 51

5.2 Findings related to Research Question 2 53

5.3 Findings related to Research Question 3 55

6 Discussion 57

6.1 Moving continuous improvement beyond organisational boundaries 57

6.2 Enabling collaborative improvement through emergent interaction 61

6.3 Facilitation as a core mechanism of collaborative improvement 64

6.4 Practical implications for collaborative improvement 67

6.5 Methodological discussion 69

7 Conclusions 72

7.1 RQ1: What factors enable collaborative improvement across organisational boundaries? 72

7.2 RQ2: How does collaboration across organisational boundaries support the generation and development of ideas? 73

7.3 RQ3: How does facilitation influence the generation and development of ideas across organisational boundaries? 74

7.4 Suggestions for future research 75

8 References 77

List of terms and definitions

Collaborative improvement: Joint efforts by multiple actors to create changes—ranging from incremental improvements to more novel innovations—across organisational boundaries.

Co-creation: The process through which multiple stakeholders actively contribute to the joint creation of value rather than receiving it passively.

Ecosystem: A network of interdependent actors (organisations, individuals, institutions) that interact and integrate resources to create value, which is characterised by loosely coupled relationships, adaptability, and the absence of central control.

Engagement and motivation: The individual and collective drivers that influence participation and sustain collaborative processes over time.

Facilitation: The deliberate guidance of group processes to support interaction, learning, and the co-creation of ideas and solutions.

Idea generation and development: Processes through which ideas emerge, are refined, and are translated into improvements or innovations.

Improvement: Changes that enhance value, performance, or quality, typically through iterative and incremental development, thereby forming the lower end of a continuum that also includes innovation.

Improvement capability: An organisation's ability to systematically identify, develop, and implement improvements over time.

Innovation: The development and implementation of new or significantly changed ideas, practices, or solutions that create value, thereby representing larger-scale change within the improvement continuum.

Inter-organisational interaction: The interactions and collaborative processes that occur among autonomous organisations, often in the context of more bounded or temporary settings such as projects or facilitated exchanges.

Open-TQM: An extension of traditional Total Quality Management that emphasises openness, collaboration, and improvement across organisational boundaries.

Service design: An approach that uses structured, participatory methods to design services both with and for stakeholders.

Structure and process: The formal arrangements and practical activities that organise and enable collaboration.

Trust: The expectation that other actors will act reliably and in good faith, enabling open communication, knowledge sharing, and sustained collaboration.

Abstract

Continuous improvement has long been a central part of Quality Management (QM), where organisational improvement and development have mainly been studied within the boundaries of single organisations. Many contemporary societal and organisational challenges require collaboration across organisational boundaries. Improvement in these settings depends on the ability of multiple actors to work together, share knowledge, and develop ideas collectively. Although inter-organisational collaboration has received increasing attention, less is known about how improvement and innovation actually develop across organisational boundaries.

The purpose of this licentiate thesis is to contribute to a deeper understanding of how organisations can work together to improve and innovate across boundaries. This thesis explores how collaborative improvement in organisational ecosystems can strengthen quality by enabling the generation and development of ideas across organisational boundaries. Three research questions guide this thesis. RQ1: What factors enable collaborative improvement across organisational boundaries? RQ2: How does collaboration across organisational boundaries support the generation and development of ideas? Finally, RQ3: How does facilitation influence the generation and development of ideas across organisational boundaries?

This thesis is based on a qualitative multi-method design that consists of three interrelated studies. The first study is a systematic literature review that explores collaborative improvement in inter-organisational contexts. The second study examines co-creation and

collaborative improvement in two rural development ecosystems in Sweden. The third study explores how facilitation influences idea generation and development in the context of inter-organisational experiential exchanges within a transnational tourism initiative. Empirical data were collected through interviews, participant observations, and document analysis.

The findings show that collaborative improvement depends on a combination of structural and relational conditions. Trust, shared direction, engagement, facilitation, and opportunities for repeated interaction emerged as particularly important. Rather than being transferred directly between organisations, ideas are shaped through interaction, reflection, and adaptation to local contexts. Facilitation plays a central role in shaping these processes by creating conditions that support participation, interaction, and collective sense-making across organisational boundaries.

This thesis contributes to QM research by extending continuous improvement beyond the level of single organisations and towards ecosystemic and inter-organisational contexts. Collaborative improvement is understood not as a predefined system or structure but rather as an ongoing and interaction-driven process that develops through relationships, co-creation, and facilitation over time.

Keywords: Quality Management, collaborative improvement, collaborative innovation, facilitation, co-creation, continuous improvement, inter-organisational collaboration, idea generation, rural development.

Summary in Swedish

Ständiga förbättringar har länge varit en central del av kvalitetsutveckling, där organisatoriskt förbättrings- och utvecklingsarbete främst har studerats inom enskilda organisationer. Många av dagens samhälleliga och organisatoriska utmaningar kräver dock samverkan över organisationsgränser. I sådana sammanhang är förbättringsarbete beroende av att flera aktörer kan arbeta tillsammans, dela kunskap och utveckla idéer gemensamt. Trots ett ökat intresse för interorganisatoriskt förbättringsarbete finns det fortfarande begränsad kunskap om hur ständiga förbättringar och innovation faktiskt fungerar när flera organisationer är involverade.

Syftet med denna licentiatavhandling är att bidra till en fördjupad förståelse för hur organisationer kan arbeta tillsammans med ständiga förbättringar och innovation över organisationsgränser. I avhandlingen används begreppet *collaborative improvement* för förbättringsarbete som sker genom samverkan. Fokus ligger på hur förbättringsarbete i interorganisatoriska kontexter kan stärka kvalitet genom att skapa möjligheter för idéer att genereras och utvecklas över organisationsgränser. Avhandlingen utgår från tre forskningsfrågor: 1) Vilka faktorer möjliggör *collaborative improvement* över organisationsgränser? 2) Hur stödjer samverkan över organisationsgränser generering och utveckling av idéer? 3) Hur påverkar facilitering generering och utveckling av idéer över organisationsgränser?

Avhandlingen bygger på en kvalitativ forskningsdesign med flera metoder och omfattar tre sammanlänkade studier. Den första är en

systematisk litteraturöversikt om *collaborative improvement* i interorganisatoriska sammanhang. Den andra studien undersöker samskapande och *collaborative improvement* i två ekosystem för landsbygdsutveckling i Sverige. Den tredje studien undersöker hur facilitering påverkar generering och utveckling av idéer i interorganisatoriska erfarenhetsutbyten inom ett transnationellt turisminitiativ. Det empiriska materialet består av intervjuer, deltagande observationer och dokumentanalyser.

Resultaten visar att *collaborative improvement* är beroende av både strukturella och relationella förutsättningar. Tillit, gemensam riktning, engagemang, facilitering och möjligheter till återkommande interaktion framträder som särskilt viktiga. Resultaten visar också att idéer inte överförs direkt mellan organisationer. I stället formas och utvecklas de genom interaktion, reflektion och anpassning till lokala sammanhang. Facilitering har en viktig roll i dessa processer genom att skapa förutsättningar för deltagande, interaktion och gemensamt meningsskapande över organisationsgränser.

Avhandlingen bidrar till forskning inom kvalitetsutveckling genom att vidga perspektivet på ständiga förbättringar från den enskilda organisationen till interorganisatoriska och ekosystemiska sammanhang. *Collaborative improvement* betraktas inte som ett på förhand definierat system eller en fast struktur, utan som en pågående process som utvecklas över tid genom interaktion, relationer, samskapande och facilitering.

Nyckelord: kvalitetsutveckling, *collaborative improvement*, *collaborative innovation*, facilitering, samskapande, ständiga förbättringar, interorganisatorisk samverkan, idégenerering, landsbygdsutveckling

List of appended papers

Paper A

Östberg, L. & Eriksson, M. (2023). Collaborative improvement as a driver for excellence – findings from a systematic literature review. 26th Excellence in Services International Conference (31 August–1 September 2023, University of West Scotland, Paisley): Conference Proceedings.

Contribution: Led the systematic literature review, including data collection, analysis, and manuscript writing.

Paper B

Östberg, L., Snyder, K., & Lilja, J. (2025). Key Factors Driving the Co-Creation of Collaborative Improvement and Innovation in Rural Development Ecosystems. *Journal of Service Theory and Practice,* 36(7), 24-45. https://doi.org/10.1108/JSTP-05-2025-0177

Contribution: Led data collection and interviews, conducted participant observation, and was primarily responsible for analysis and manuscript writing in collaboration with co-authors.

Paper C

Östberg, L. (2026). Ideas in the Making: Advancing Open-TQM by Understanding the Role of Facilitation in Inter-Organisational Improvement.
Submitted 2026-04-10 to *Total Quality Management & Business Excellence*

Contribution: Single author

Preface

This thesis has come together through many long working sessions, although not always in front of the computer. Whenever I got stuck, which happened quite often, I usually went outside—out onto a mountain, into the forest, or somewhere else in nature. During ski tours, runs, bike rides, and long walks, many of the missing pieces slowly started to fall into place. Often, ideas appeared when there was finally enough space for thoughts, impressions, and experiences to connect.

Just as many insights came through meetings and conversations with people. At workshops involving cycling entrepreneurs, in local development projects, or through completely unplanned encounters at a grocery store or café back home in Funäsdalen. A quick conversation could suddenly turn into a discussion about collaboration, tourism, local development, or shared challenges that needed to be solved. New ideas often emerged somewhere between people's different perspectives, experiences, and contexts.

In many ways, this thesis itself is also a product of co-creation. The articles, the discussions, and, eventually, this thesis have developed in interaction with others. Through workshops, conversations, shared experiences, reflections, and collaboration across organisational and disciplinary boundaries.

Serendipity has followed this work throughout the process. Not only in unexpected encounters but also in the way ideas seem to emerge when people, perspectives, and experiences are allowed to connect across places and contexts.

I hope that you, as a reader, will find something here that feels relevant to your own context and practice. Above all, I hope that some of these ideas continue to live outside these pages, particularly in networks, organisations, villages, businesses, projects, and collaborations in which people meet and try to create something together. Because that is where interesting things happen. It is in the interaction between people, organisations, and perspectives that our real potential emerges.

Anicca.

Louise Östberg

Funäsdalen, November 2026

1 Introduction

The purpose of this chapter is to provide an overview of the background and context of the thesis, and to present the purpose and research questions.

1.1 Background

Continuous improvement has long been a cornerstone of Quality Management (QM). Drawing on approaches such as Kaizen, Lean, and Total Quality Management (TQM) – management philosophies that focus on systematic, incremental change – continuous improvement can be promoted through small, ongoing changes and engaging those closest to the processes, who are often best positioned to identify improvements (e.g. Bhuiyan & Baghel, 2005; Robinson, 1991; Shingo, 1988). Within single organisations, these practices have been shown to support organisational learning and adaptability, contributing to the development of improvement capability and long-term performance (Anand et al., 2009; Bessant & Francis, 1999), which helps explain why improvement capability has often been treated as an internal organisational asset. As a result, research on continuous improvement has predominantly examined processes within organisational boundaries, where managers can mobilise resources, set goals, and embed routines through formal systems (Jurburg et al., 2017).

As organisations have become increasingly interconnected, it has become increasingly difficult to view improvement as something that happens within the boundaries of a single firm (Granstrand & Holgersson, 2020). Many contemporary organisational and societal challenges require joint efforts across organisational boundaries (Dodgson, 2014). These issues are not confined to global industries or large urban systems but are also evident in rural regions, where

demographic shifts, resource constraints, and pressures for local development create challenges that individual actors may have limited capacity to address alone, making collaboration across organisational boundaries particularly important (e.g., Bosworth et al., 2020; Zahoor & Al-Tabbaa, 2020).

When challenges cross organisational boundaries, improvement needs to become collaborative. This shift changes the conditions under which improvement takes place, as multiple autonomous actors must align their efforts despite having different organisational contexts, interests, and resources. Collaborative improvement therefore depends on the ability of multiple actors to combine their resources, expertise, and perspectives to achieve outcomes that none of them could realise on their own (Plsek, 1997; Zacharia et al., 2019). Collaborative improvement has been studied in areas such as healthcare networks, educational partnerships, and regional development, where it has been shown to create results that go beyond what individual actors could achieve alone (Mervyn et al., 2019; Russell et al., 2017). Collaborative improvement extends QM from the level of single organisations towards system-level improvement and innovation (Bessant et al., 2001). This shift resonates with the open innovation perspective, which highlights how ideas and resources flow across organisational boundaries (Chesbrough et al., 2006).

Working across organisational boundaries is, however, not straightforward. Actors often differ in culture, resources, and priorities. These challenges become particularly apparent in ecosystem contexts, where interdependent actors and their activities are connected without necessarily being governed by a central coordinating authority (Adner, 2016; Carida et al., 2022). In such

loosely connected settings, there may be no single actor to coordinate efforts or mandate participation. Collaborative improvement therefore cannot be built on the same assumptions as improvement within a single organisation, where authority, goals, and routines are more consolidated (Ansell & Gash, 2008; Powell, 1990). Instead, improvement across organisational boundaries depends on enabling conditions such as trust, a shared sense of purpose, and supportive structures and processes (Bryson et al., 2021; Dovey, 2009; Worley et al., 2022). Prior research highlights the importance of conditions such as frameworks, resources, facilitation, leadership, urgency, and trust (Kożuch & Sienkiewicz-Małyjurek, 2016; Worley et al., 2022). However, how these conditions work together in practice remains unclear.

Co-creation provides one useful lens for studying these dynamics. It involves multiple stakeholders jointly identifying needs, developing ideas, and implementing solutions. Co-creation has become an important perspective in service design and public services (Trischler & Westman Trischler, 2022), while Service-Dominant Logic provides a foundation for understanding value co-creation (Vargo & Lusch, 2016). Rather than viewing actors as passive recipients, co-creation recognises their active role in creating value within their specific contexts (Helkkula et al., 2018). Although co-creation has received attention in the fields of public services and innovation management, its role in enabling collaborative improvement across organisational boundaries remains underexplored (Zahoor & Al-Tabbaa, 2020).

The role played by facilitation in collaborative improvement merits greater attention, as its importance has been widely acknowledged but remains insufficiently understood (Bryson et al., 2021; Harvey & Lynch, 2017; Torfing et al., 2019). Collaborative improvement does

not occur automatically when organisations meet. Rather, it requires intentional design and support. Facilitation can be viewed as a mechanism that connects the everyday interactions of individuals with broader outcomes at the ecosystem level (Bryson et al., 2021; Torfing et al., 2019). Good facilitation helps create environments in which diverse actors feel included, dialogue remains constructive despite different perspectives, and ideas are supported and developed.

Improvement and innovation are also closely connected. Improvement has often been viewed as incremental and innovation as more radical, but in practice, the two overlap and can be viewed as points on a continuum of change (Bessant et al., 2001; Paulus et al., 2018). Collaborative initiatives may start with small adjustments that grow into larger transformations, or they may allow new ideas to emerge that would not have been possible in isolation (Van de Ven, 1999). This makes the processes of idea generation and development particularly important to study, especially in ecosystems that lack formal hierarchies or shared infrastructures.

Despite the promise of collaborative improvement, systematic knowledge about how facilitation, co-creation, and idea generation interact in ecosystems remains limited. This represents an important gap in the field of QM, where continuous improvement has been central within organisations but remains less understood across organisational boundaries.

This gap is not only theoretical; it also has important practical implications. Many contemporary societal and local challenges, including those related to sustainable development and regional resilience, require collaboration and co-creation across organisational

and sectoral boundaries, as no single organisation can act alone. For municipalities, businesses, community organisations, and other actors involved, the challenge is therefore not simply to bring stakeholders together, but also to create conditions that enable them to collaborate, share knowledge, and develop ideas across organisational boundaries. Such collaboration can support more adaptive and locally relevant improvements and strengthen the actors' capacity to improve together.

Addressing this gap motivates the purpose and research questions of this thesis.

1.2 Purpose and research questions

The purpose of this thesis is to contribute to a deeper understanding of how organisations can work together to improve and innovate across boundaries. It explores how collaborative improvement in organisational ecosystems can strengthen quality by enabling the generation and development of ideas across boundaries.

Building on this purpose, the thesis is guided by three research questions:

RQ1. What factors enable collaborative improvement across organisational boundaries?

RQ2. How does collaboration across organisational boundaries support the generation and development of ideas?

RQ3. How does facilitation influence the generation and development of ideas across organisational boundaries?

1.3 Connection between Research Questions and Papers

The three research questions are addressed through the three papers included in this thesis. The papers explore enabling conditions for collaborative improvement, how collaboration supports idea generation and development, and the influence of facilitation in these processes across organisational boundaries.

The first research question focuses on identifying factors that enable collaborative improvement in inter-organisational contexts. This question is addressed across all three papers, which together provide a conceptual and empirical basis for understanding enabling conditions in different settings.

The second research question examines how collaboration supports the generation and development of ideas. This is explored through empirical studies of collaborative processes in organisational ecosystems, which highlight how interaction among diverse actors shapes idea development.

The third research question examines how facilitation influences idea generation and development across organisational boundaries. This question is addressed through studies of how facilitation contributes to structuring interaction and enabling collaborative processes.

Table 1.

Research question	Paper(s)	Focus
RQ1. What factors enable collaborative improvement across organisational boundaries?	Paper A, B & C	Identifies enabling factors such as trust, shared goals, and supportive structures
RQ2. How does collaboration across boundaries support the generation and development of ideas?	Paper B & C	Explores how ideas emerge and develop through interaction and co-creation in ecosystems
RQ3. How does facilitation influence the generation and development of ideas across organisational boundaries?	Paper B & C	Examines how facilitation supports idea generation and collaborative improvement

2 Theoretical frame of reference

This chapter introduces the theories and concepts that form the foundation of the thesis. Continuous improvement and innovation are central concepts within Quality Management, providing a basis for understanding how organisations systematically develop quality and respond to changing needs. By building on these concepts, the thesis moves beyond individual organisations to collaborative improvement, which is understood in terms of joint efforts to create changes ranging from incremental improvement to more novel innovation. Idea generation and development represent important components of the process through which such change may emerge, whereas co-creation provides a relevant perspective on how actors jointly engage in this process.

The chapter begins with a Quality Management perspective on continuous improvement and innovation, before expanding to collaboration across organisational boundaries. Collaborative improvement is then introduced as the overarching phenomenon of interest, followed by idea generation and development and, finally, co-creation as a perspective on collaborative processes.

2.1 Continuous improvement and innovation as a part of Quality Management

Continuous improvement has long been a cornerstone of QM. It is commonly described as an ongoing process that involves making small, incremental changes with the aim of enhancing routines, products, or services (Bhuiyan & Baghel, 2005; Robinson, 1991; Shingo, 1988). Within the QM tradition, continuous improvement is viewed as essential for long-term competitiveness and organisational excellence (Bergman et al., 2022; Bessant et al., 1994). It also reflects a cultural dimension, according to which improvement is not limited to

top management or special projects but rather becomes part of everyday work, thereby engaging employees at all levels (Jurburg et al., 2017). Recent studies reinforce this view, showing that continuous improvement practices contribute not only to operational excellence but also to the development of dynamic capabilities that enable organisations to adapt to changing environments (Gutierrez & Antony, 2019).

Innovation has often been distinguished from continuous improvement by its association with novelty and, at times, radical change. Yet the boundary between the two is not clear-cut. Incremental innovation shares many characteristics with continuous improvement, and both can be seen as points on a continuum of change (Audretsch et al., 2011; Bessant et al., 2001). While radical innovation may involve disruptive new products, services, or business models, incremental innovation and continuous improvement both build on learning processes, experimentation, and knowledge sharing (Bessant et al., 2001).

Many organisations combine both approaches, balancing smaller, step-by-step improvements with more transformative initiatives to remain adaptable in complex environments (Bessant et al., 2001; Tushman & O'Reilly, 1996). This dual capacity has often been described in terms of organisational ambidexterity, which emphasises the need to exploit existing processes while simultaneously exploring new opportunities (O'Reilly & Tushman, 2013; Tushman & O'Reilly, 1996).

Ideas are central to both continuous improvement and innovation. Both depend on the ability to generate, develop, and implement ideas over time. Ideas can be viewed as the “raw material” for change;

without them, neither improvement nor innovation is possible (Robinson & Schroeder, 2004). This makes it important for organisations to establish structures and processes that encourage idea generation, refinement, and implementation. Research on creativity and collaborative ideation shows that diversity of perspectives and systematic approaches can enhance both the quality and the feasibility of new ideas (Paulus et al., 2018; Reinig et al., 2007). Recent meta-analytic evidence has suggested that QM dimensions are positively associated with different forms of innovation, with leadership styles acting as important moderators in the QM-innovation relationship (El Manzani et al., 2025).

The literature positions continuous improvement and innovation as complementary dimensions of QM. Both are rooted in learning and idea development, and together they support organisational adaptability, quality development, and excellence. Improvement and innovation can therefore be understood as interconnected forms of change along a continuum, ranging from incremental improvements to more novel innovations.

2.2 Collaboration across boundaries in inter-organisational contexts

Collaboration across organisational boundaries has been studied through several related concepts, including inter-organisational systems, networks, partnerships, and ecosystems. These approaches share an interest in how organisations interact to achieve outcomes that they could not accomplish alone, yet they emphasise different features of collaboration. Although these concepts overlap in scope, they have often been used inconsistently in the literature, and the evidence base regarding how collaboration actually works across

boundaries remains fragmented (Bryson et al., 2021; Castañer & Oliveira, 2020).

Early research on inter-organisational systems (IOS) focused on the structural and governance aspects of collaboration. IOS have often been understood as relatively formalised arrangements between organisations that are frequently supported by information systems and contractual agreements (Johnston & Vitale, 1988; Kumar & van Dissel, 1996). In QM and supply chain research, IOS have been examined as mechanisms to coordinate activities, share information, and improve efficiency across organisational boundaries (Kaynak & Hartley, 2008). Related literature on inter-organisational networks has emphasised patterns of relationships, roles, and governance structures (Provan & Kenis, 2008), suggesting that trust, legitimacy, and shared purpose are key to sustaining collaboration.

In parallel, research on collaborative governance and partnerships has addressed how actors who have diverse goals and resources come together in public and non-profit contexts. Here, collaboration is viewed as both a necessity in addressing complex societal problems and as a process shaped by facilitation, trust-building, and inclusive decision-making (Ansell & Gash, 2008; Bryson et al., 2021). These perspectives highlight that formal authority is often lacking in boundary-spanning collaboration, which makes progress more dependent on voluntary engagement and mutual adjustment.

More recently, ecosystem theory has offered a complementary lens. Ecosystems are characterised by loosely coupled actors that are interdependent yet autonomous, and that jointly create value through resource integration and idea exchange (Adner, 2016; Jacobides et al., 2018). Unlike traditional IOS, ecosystems emphasise adaptability, co-

evolution, and the emergence of outcomes in the absence of centralised control (Carida et al., 2022; Edvardsson et al., 2012). In such contexts, boundaries may be fluid, and the focus shifts from bilateral relationships to the wider constellation of actors, including public, private, and community stakeholders.

These characteristics also create tensions in ecosystem collaboration. Actors remain autonomous and pursue their own interests, while simultaneously depending on others for resources, knowledge, or actions (Adner, 2016; Jacobides et al., 2018). Without central authority, some degree of structure and coordination therefore needs to coexist with the adaptive and emergent nature of ecosystem development (Carida et al., 2022; Vink et al., 2020). Organisational boundaries also remain important, since actors retain their own goals, resources, and responsibilities, even when collaboration requires knowledge exchange and mutual adjustment across them (Kożuch & Sienkiewicz-Małyjurek, 2016; Provan & Kenis, 2008). The boundaries and composition of the ecosystem may shift as actors enter, leave, or change their roles and contributions over time (Coletto et al., 2024; Granstrand & Holgersson, 2020). Understanding collaboration in ecosystems therefore involves paying attention not only to individual actors and bilateral relationships but also to the dependencies and interactions that develop across the wider system.

How these dynamics play out may also depend on the ecosystem context. In rural and community-based ecosystems, collaboration may be shaped by place-based conditions and constraints on local resources (Bock, 2016). Participation may also rely heavily on voluntary engagement, where motivation and perceived opportunities to contribute become important for sustaining involvement (Fernandes & de Matos, 2023). In these settings, formal

structures alone are therefore unlikely to sustain collaboration; continued participation also depends on actors being willing and able to remain engaged over time.

IOS and network perspectives draw attention to structures, relationships, coordination, and governance (Kumar & van Dissel, 1996; Provan & Kenis, 2008), while an ecosystem perspective places greater emphasis on interdependence, adaptation, and processes that develop across a wider constellation of autonomous actors (Granstrand & Holgersson, 2020; Jacobides et al., 2018).

In this thesis, the ecosystem perspective is used as an analytical lens rather than as a label for all the inter-organisational contexts studied. The broader focus of the thesis is collaborative improvement across organisational boundaries. An ecosystem perspective draws attention to contexts where outcomes depend on interactions among multiple autonomous and interdependent actors (Adner, 2016; Jacobides et al., 2018). Ecosystems also change over time as actors, their roles, and their relationships evolve (Coletto et al., 2024; Granstrand & Holgersson, 2020). Together, these perspectives highlight the importance of relationships and dependencies that extend beyond individual organisations (Granstrand & Holgersson, 2020; Jacobides et al., 2018). This provides the basis for using the ecosystem perspective to understand how collaborative improvement may develop through interactions across a wider system.

2.3 Collaborative improvement

The concept of collaborative improvement has emerged to describe situations where multiple organisations work together to achieve outcomes that no single actor could accomplish alone (Plsek, 1997). This reflects what Aristotle expressed with the phrase *holon para ta*

moria, which refers to the idea that the whole can be greater than the sum of its parts (Husain, 2001). In collaborative improvement, organisations combine resources, knowledge, and perspectives, creating synergies and opportunities that would not appear if they acted separately (Mervyn et al., 2019).

Studies have highlighted a number of recurring conditions that make collaborative improvement possible. Reviews and empirical studies emphasise trust, shared goals, and supportive structures and processes as particularly important (Bryson et al., 2021; Kożuch & Sienkiewicz-Małyjurek, 2016; Russell et al., 2017). Trust makes it possible to share knowledge without fear of misuse. Shared goals help align different actors, even if it is not always clear how a shared vision actually develops in practice. Structures and processes, such as frameworks and arenas for interaction, provide scaffolding that supports collaboration over the course of time.

In collaborative settings, leadership is often described as distributed and relational rather than centred on a single actor (Sullivan et al., 2012). It can involve a variety of functions, such as coordinating, facilitating, and sustaining collaboration over time. From this perspective, facilitation can be understood as a collaborative leadership practice that focuses on supporting interaction, dialogue, and joint problem-solving among participants. Similarly, Emerson et al. (2012) described collaborative leadership as covering multiple roles, including sponsors, conveners, and facilitators, thus emphasising the role of facilitation as one way leadership is enacted in practice.

This indicates that leadership and facilitation are closely related, but not always equivalent to each other. Alongside these, sustained

participation and commitment among actors are important for maintaining collaboration over time (Worley et al., 2022).

The interaction between structure and engagement is vital. Structures create legitimacy, predictability, and direction, while engagement ensures that collaboration is meaningful and not merely formal compliance. Studies of community and regional development show how facilitation, credibility, and resources can provide legitimacy and direction for collaboration, while trust, leadership, and personal commitment can sustain active participation. External pressures, such as demographic decline or economic uncertainty, may also generate urgency that drives actors to come together (Bryson et al., 2021). Collaborative improvement is therefore not only an organisational or technical exercise, but also a social process shaped by relationships, identities, and local circumstances (Bosworth et al., 2020; Fernandes & de Matos, 2023).

Collaborative improvement is far from straightforward. It can be hindered by differences in culture, asymmetries in resources, and conflicting priorities (Kożuch & Sienkiewicz-Małyjurek, 2016; Provan & Kenis, 2008). In the absence of supportive structures, collaboration risks becoming fragmented or symbolic (Ansell & Gash, 2008). Furthermore, in the absence of genuine engagement, it risks remaining superficial and failing to create meaningful outcomes (Russell et al., 2017; Worley et al., 2022). Scholars have therefore reported that collaborative improvement requires both scaffolding and energy, since formal arrangements alone rarely generate collaborative advantages in the absence of trust, engagement, and shared purpose (Bosworth et al., 2020; Huxham & Vangen, 2005).

Collaborative improvement extends the principles of continuous improvement into inter-organisational contexts. This development also aligns with more recent discussions of Open-TQM, which have emphasised openness, inter-organisational interaction, and improvement capability across organisational boundaries and ecosystems (Dezi et al., 2025). These contexts bring greater complexity but also offer the potential for outcomes that exceed what individual organisations can achieve. The essence of collaborative improvement lies in creating conditions where actors can combine resources, align around shared purposes, and, most importantly, generate and develop ideas together. The following section examines idea generation and development as a central process in the context of collaborative improvement.

2.4 Idea generation and development in collaborative settings

Ideas are the basis for both continuous improvement and innovation. Within QM, ideas are often described as the "raw material" of improvement, as they represent the starting point for refining existing practices and developing new solutions (Robinson & Schroeder, 2004). Both continuous improvement and innovation depend on the ability to generate, develop, and implement ideas over time (Bessant et al., 2001).

Idea generation has traditionally been studied mostly within single organisations (Kornish & Hutchison-Krupat, 2017), where structured systems and routines support the collection and implementation of suggestions. Less attention has been paid to the question of how ideas emerge and develop in inter-organisational settings (Buganza et al., 2011). Ideation processes in inter-organisational contexts differ

from those within individual organisations (Heil & Bornemann, 2018). Research on collaborative ideation has suggested that combining diverse perspectives can enhance the quality and novelty of ideas, particularly when participants engage in dialogue and joint problem-solving (Paulus et al., 2018; Reinig et al., 2007).

Idea generation may also involve serendipity, where unexpected events, encounters, or observations lead to valuable discoveries that were not deliberately sought (Busch, 2024). Serendipity is therefore more than chance alone, as it also involves recognising and acting on the potential value of the unexpected (Busch, 2024). In collaborative settings, unplanned interactions can expose actors to different knowledge and perspectives, creating opportunities for new connections and ideas to emerge (Olshannikova et al., 2020; Roth, 2022).

At the same time, diversity can also make collaborative ideation challenging, as differences in organisational cultures, knowledge bases, priorities, and goals may hinder communication, create misunderstandings, or lead to conflicting interpretations of problems and solutions (Kożuch & Sienkiewicz-Małyjurek, 2016; Provan & Kenis, 2008).

In inter-organisational settings, ideas rarely transfer directly from one context to another. Instead, ideas must be interpreted, adapted, and aligned with local organisational conditions (Argote & Miron-Spektor, 2011). This highlights that idea development is not a linear process of adoption, but rather an iterative process of sensemaking, where actors continuously interpret knowledge in interaction with others (Smith, 2016).

Many ideas that emerge in collaborative settings are incremental in nature. In line with the research on continuous improvement, many ideas concern small adjustments, refinements, or combinations of existing practices (Bessant et al., 2001; Jurburg et al., 2017). Small ideas can accumulate over time and contribute to more substantial changes.

The emergence and development of ideas are dependent on the conditions under which collaboration takes place (Emerson et al., 2012; Kożuch & Sienkiewicz-Małyjurek, 2016). Previous research has emphasised that factors such as trust, shared goals, and supportive structures and processes are critical for enabling interaction and knowledge sharing across organisational boundaries (Emerson et al., 2012; Kożuch & Sienkiewicz-Małyjurek, 2016; Worley et al., 2022). Within these structures, facilitation is one factor that can support interaction among participants. Facilitation can support interaction, dialogue, and reflection, helping participants engage with one another, compare perspectives, and explore ideas collectively (Worley et al., 2022). In inter-organisational contexts, where actors often differ in background, experience, and expectations, facilitation can support more inclusive participation and help reduce barriers to communication and knowledge exchange (Worley et al., 2022). In the absence of supportive conditions, actors may be reluctant to share and build on ideas, limiting the potential for collaborative ideation (Paulus et al., 2018).

Co-creation provides one perspective for understanding these collaborative processes and is discussed in the following section.

2.5 Co-creation in collaborative improvement

Co-creation has become an important concept for understanding how improvement efforts can extend across organisational boundaries. In Service-Dominant Logic, co-creation is understood as a principle of value creation, where actors integrate their resources through ongoing interaction (Vargo & Lusch, 2016). This perspective represents a shift from the traditional view of value as something produced by one actor and delivered to another, towards value as something that is created jointly in use and interaction. Co-creation refers to processes where stakeholders identify needs together, then develop ideas and implement solutions rather than viewing improvements as something delivered by one actor to another (Helkkula et al., 2018). In this thesis, co-creation provides a perspective for understanding how actors work together, learn collectively, and incorporate different perspectives in collaborative improvement. Such collaborative processes can lead to outcomes that are both innovative and relevant to the context (Trischler & Westman Trischler, 2022).

Several studies stress that co-creation is not only about participation but also about designing conditions where collaboration becomes meaningful. This involves coordinating people, processes, and tools in ways that allow different actors to contribute and to see their perspectives reflected in outcomes (e.g. Prestes Joly et al., 2019; Sangiorgi & Prendiville, 2017). Co-creation has been applied in fields such as public services and community development to generate solutions that better reflect the needs of users and stakeholders (Voorberg et al., 2017). In innovation contexts specifically, co-creation has been shown to act as a mechanism for aligning stakeholder

expectations and enhancing mutual understanding (Takahashi & Takahashi, 2021). Co-creation is particularly relevant in contexts where resources are scarce and must be integrated across actors (Barile et al., 2020). It is also important in settings where engagement is voluntary, since relevance and a sense of ownership are vital to sustaining change (Peng & Lin, 2016).

Service design has often been used as a practical approach to structure co-creation. This approach emphasises participatory methods and offers concrete activities, workshops, and tools that can help support collaboration (Stickdorn & Schneider, 2012). In public service contexts, service design has also been shown to help organise value co-creation among diverse stakeholders (Trischler & Westman Trischler, 2022). More recent developments have extended this towards a service ecosystem perspective, where the orchestration of multiple actors and resources is necessary (Carida et al., 2022) and where institutions and practices can be intentionally shaped to support co-creation (Vink et al., 2020). This perspective is particularly relevant in rural or community-based ecosystems, where diverse stakeholders may need to coordinate their efforts in resource-constrained settings (Bock, 2016).

In the context of collaborative improvement, co-creation highlights how stakeholder engagement and interaction can contribute to sustained change. By combining different forms of knowledge, co-creative processes can support improvement initiatives that reflect the perspectives and needs of the actors involved. When supported by approaches such as service design, co-creation can help organise collaboration and support the development of ideas. This is consistent with the claim that value is created through interaction and resource integration (Vargo & Lusch, 2016).

3 Research Methodology

This chapter outlines the research methodology for this research, including its philosophical foundations, my preunderstanding, methodological approach and design, and reflections on research quality and ethical considerations.

3.1 Philosophical worldview

The philosophical foundations of research shape how inquiry is conceived, conducted, and interpreted. Ontology concerns assumptions about the nature of reality, while epistemology addresses how knowledge is produced and understood (Al-Ababneh, 2020; Crotty, 1998). These assumptions influence the entire research process, ranging from the formulation of research questions to the interpretation of findings. This alignment between philosophical assumptions and research design is particularly important in studies of socially constructed phenomena such as collaboration and innovation in organisational ecosystems (Creswell & Poth, 2023).

My research focuses primarily on continuous improvement and innovation in inter-organisational or ecosystemic contexts. These systems, whether they are referred to as networks, inter-organisational relations, ecosystems, or related terms, involve diverse actors and organisations working across boundaries to address multifaceted societal, organisational, and contextual challenges. Given the complexity, relational nature, and context-dependence of such systems, a qualitative research design was considered most appropriate for addressing the research questions. A qualitative multi-method approach is suited for capturing the dynamics of interaction, the diversity of perspectives, and the situated nature of improvement and innovation processes.

My research adopts a pragmatist-constructivist stance, which is grounded in the understanding that knowledge is both socially constructed and valued for its capacity to guide meaningful action. From a constructivist perspective, reality is not singular or fixed but rather multiple, situated, and co-constructed through interactions among actors in specific contexts (Al-Ababneh, 2020; Guba & Lincoln, 1994). Knowledge therefore emerges through ongoing processes of interpretation and negotiation, where researchers and participants jointly contribute to meaning-making. This perspective is reflected in the focus of this thesis on how actors jointly make sense of collaboration and improvement processes within their specific contexts.

This approach implies that the researcher is not a detached observer but rather a co-actor who is embedded in the social context, whose position may shift between that of an insider and an outsider depending on the situation at hand (Dwyer & Buckle, 2009). Knowledge production is therefore inseparable from how the researcher engages with and interprets the research setting (Aluwihare-Samaranayake, 2012; Crotty, 1998). In this research, my embedded position within the studied contexts involved both participating in and observing collaborative processes. This approach influenced my ability to access empirical settings as well as my interpretations of interactions and meanings, thus making reflexivity a central component of the research process. Such reflexivity is particularly important in qualitative interpretive research, where the researcher's involvement shapes both the generation and interpretation of data, and where making this influence explicit contributes to transparency and methodological rigour (Aluwihare-Samaranayake, 2012; Braun & Clarke, 2022).

From a pragmatist perspective, knowledge is considered valid when it proves useful in addressing real-world problems (Morgan, 2014). Pragmatism connects ontology and epistemology by shifting attention from abstract notions of truth to warranted assertions, where knowledge claims are judged by their practical consequences. This perspective aligns with Dewey's (1938) view of inquiry as a reflective process through which people respond to problematic situations in their shared environment. Improvement and innovation in ecosystems follow a similar logic, as they emerge from collective effort and learning rather than from detached discovery. As Biesta (2010) emphasised, knowledge creation is always situated, value-laden, and shaped by purpose. This is particularly relevant for the present research, which seeks to generate insights that are both analytically meaningful and useful for understanding collaborative improvement in real-world contexts.

This understanding is also in line with Van de Ven's (2007) concept of *Engaged Scholarship*, which frames research as a collaborative learning process between scholars and practitioners. Through dialogue and joint inquiry, researchers and practitioners can develop a shared understanding of complex problems, thereby reinforcing a view of research as focusing on problem-solving rather than detached observation. Although the present research does not involve co-production of interventions, this perspective informs how the empirical studies are positioned in relation to practice, as they aim to generate knowledge grounded in real-world collaboration processes.

The pragmatist perspective further connects to Scandinavian traditions of collaborative research, such as interactive research (Ellström et al., 2020), which emphasises joint learning between researchers and practitioners. Although the present studies are

inspired by this tradition, they do not constitute interactive or action research in a strict sense. This research does not involve systematic intervention, co-design of change processes, or iterative cycles of planned action and evaluation. This analytical (rather than intervention-driven) orientation was chosen to allow the study of collaborative processes as they naturally unfold without influencing them through structured change efforts.

Questions concerning researcher positioning were also discussed by Cronemyr and Huge-Brodin (2024), who described how action research often involves a "mixed role" in which the researcher contributes to practice while simultaneously analysing it. In the present studies, a similar type of dual positioning is present in terms of engagement and access, although it lacks the structured intervention and change-oriented design that characterises action research.

The focus of these studies is on understanding and analysing how collaborative improvement and innovation processes develop in practice. My position as a researcher embedded in the studied contexts created opportunities to participate in dialogue and mutual learning. The studies share similarities with interactive research through their emphasis on engagement and practical relevance while remaining analytically oriented rather than intervention-driven. This distinction clarifies that the purpose of this research is to generate insight into practice rather than directly intervening in practice.

3.2 Researcher experiences and pre-understanding

All qualitative research is influenced by the researcher's background and assumptions (Silverman, 2001). My own preunderstanding is shaped by years of involvement in rural development and tourism networks in the Swedish region of Jämtland-Härjedalen. This experience has provided access to relevant research contexts and given me deeper contextual insight than would otherwise have been possible. At the same time, this familiarity may shape what I notice, the questions I ask, and how I interpret empirical situations.

In addition to this regional familiarity, I bring nearly thirty years of professional experience as a consultant supporting organisations seeking to implement improvement, innovation, and idea-generation processes. Earlier in my career, I also conducted research on employee involvement in creativity and idea development in single-organisation contexts. These experiences have given me a strong understanding of what tends to enable or hinder improvement and innovation within organisations, but they have also shaped my expectations when studying collaboration across organisational boundaries. My awareness of this background helped me remain attentive to differences between intra-organisational and inter-organisational improvement logics throughout the research process. This background also influenced how I recognised patterns, formulated questions, and interpreted empirical material.

I often occupy what Dwyer and Buckle (2009) described as the "space between" an insider and an outsider, although this position differed between the two empirical studies. In Study 2 (Paper B), I was both a researcher and a resident and entrepreneur in one of the villages

studied. My local knowledge provided me with insights into relationships, challenges, and ongoing development processes, but also meant that I entered the study with established relationships and assumptions regarding the context. In Study 3 (Paper C), my dual role was more intertwined, as I participated in the experiential exchanges both as a cycling tourism entrepreneur and as a researcher. Rather than attempting to separate these roles during the exchanges, I participated in the activities while remaining transparent about my research role; I also subsequently reflected on my position and observations.

These positions provided contextual and relational insights that would have been difficult to obtain as an external researcher, while simultaneously increasing the risk that familiarity and participation shaped what I noticed and how I interpreted events. From a pragmatist perspective, the researcher's participation and interaction with the context are not necessarily limitations to be eliminated, but rather part of how knowledge is developed through experience, interaction, and reflection (Henriksen, 2021; Morgan, 2014). Reflexivity was therefore important throughout the empirical studies—not to eliminate the influence of my position, but rather to make it visible and critically examine its implications for data collection and interpretation. The specific reflexive practices used in the studies are discussed in further detail in Section 3.6.

3.3 Research approach

To address the overall purpose of this thesis, the research adopts an exploratory and descriptive approach, aiming to generate insights into complex and context-dependent processes. An exploratory qualitative approach is suitable when a phenomenon requires further

understanding and existing knowledge does not fully capture the context being studied (Creswell, 2014). The research evolved iteratively across the three studies, as the findings of each study influenced the focus of the subsequent study. This is also consistent with the pragmatist view of inquiry as a process that develops through reflection and experience (Morgan, 2014).

Paper A provided an initial understanding of the factors that enable and support collaborative improvement across organisational boundaries. Facilitation was identified as one factor that could support collaborative improvement, while the review also showed that more research is needed to understand how such processes work in practice. These results led to a stronger focus on facilitation in Paper B, where its role was explored empirically in a rural development context. The findings presented in Paper B further highlight the importance of facilitation in supporting co-creation and collaborative improvement. Based on the findings from Papers A and B, Paper C placed a stronger focus on facilitation and explored how it influences the generation and development of ideas across organisational boundaries.

The research process was therefore not strictly linear. Findings from earlier studies informed the focus of subsequent studies, while the empirical studies contributed to the developing understanding of collaborative improvement and facilitation.

3.4 Research design and methods

The empirical work presented in this thesis consists of three interrelated studies. The research began with a systematic literature review (Paper A), which mapped current knowledge on continuous improvement and innovation in inter-organisational contexts. The

review identified several factors that may enable and support collaborative improvement, including shared goals, trust, organisational structures and processes, and facilitation. The review also showed that the evidence regarding how collaborative improvement is enabled in practice is limited and diverse. These findings informed the focus of the subsequent empirical studies:

- Study 2—Collaborative Improvement in Rural Ecosystems (Paper B)—explored collaborative improvement processes in practice within a local development initiative.
- Study 3—Ideas in the Making (Paper C) examined how facilitation and peer-to-peer learning shape idea development in cross-border tourism networks.

Although each study addresses a different aspect of collaborative improvement, they build on and complement each other. In this thesis, their findings are combined in relation to the overall purpose and research questions, rather than presenting a new analysis of the original datasets. Paper A provides a broader understanding of the factors associated with collaborative improvement, while Papers B and C explore how such factors and processes are expressed in practice in different inter-organisational settings. A comparison of the findings across the three studies makes it possible to identify recurring patterns, as well as differences and complementary insights. In this way, the synthesis builds on the individual contributions of the papers to develop an overall understanding of how collaborative improvement is enabled and how ideas emerge and develop across organisational boundaries.

The progression of these three studies over time is illustrated in Figure 1.

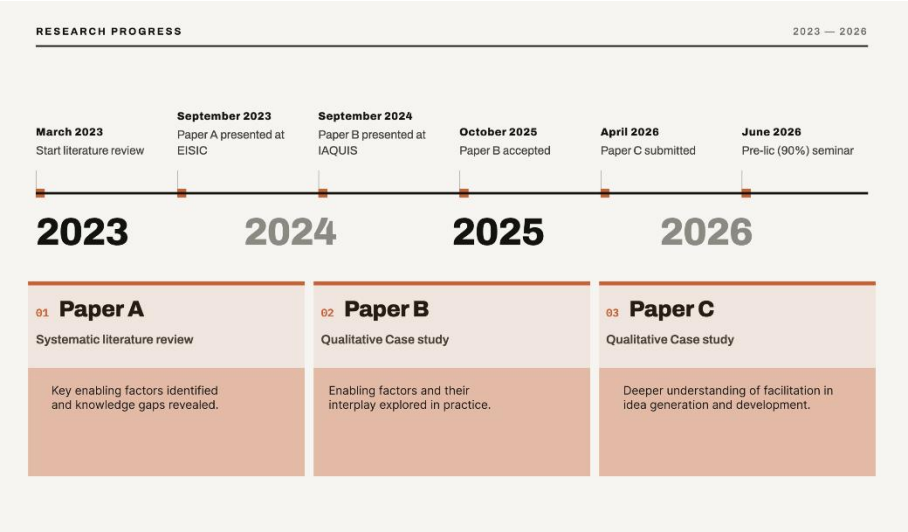


Figure 1. Overview of the progression of the three studies.

The three studies differ in design, data, and context, but they all address collaborative improvement across organisational boundaries from different perspectives. In this thesis, the findings from these studies are compared in relation to the overall research questions. The comparison is therefore made among findings rather than among the different datasets. This approach allows findings from the literature review to be considered alongside findings from the two empirical studies and highlights both similarities and differences in how collaborative improvement is enabled and develops in practice.

3.4.1 Study 1 (Paper A) – Systematic Literature Review

The first study explored how collaborative improvement can act as a driver of excellence for organisations that work together in inter-organisational systems. A systematic literature review (SLR) was

conducted to synthesise existing research on continuous or collaborative improvement initiatives across organisational boundaries (Tranfield et al., 2003). The review followed a structured and transparent approach and applied the CIMO (context-intervention-mechanism-outcome) logic (Denyer & Tranfield, 2009) to guide the formulation of review questions, search, and analysis.

Data collection for Study 1 (Paper A)

Searches were conducted in four databases: Business Source Complete, Emerald, Scopus and Web of Science. The review included peer-reviewed articles published in English between 2011 and May 2023, focusing on continuous improvement in inter-organisational contexts. The selected time frame was chosen to capture recent developments in collaborative and inter-organisational improvement, as research in this field has expanded significantly over the past decade. Limiting the review to this period also allowed for a focused and in-depth analysis of relevant studies while maintaining a manageable and analytically coherent dataset. Two search tracks were used to capture both the term "collaborative improvement" and related concepts. Following the screening process and the removal of duplicates, 21 articles were retained. A snowball search (Gough et al., 2012) added seven additional articles, resulting in a final sample of 28 articles.

Data analysis for Study 1 (Paper A)

The selected articles were analysed through a structured synthesis process following established SLR procedures (Tranfield et al., 2003). This analysis involved coding and clustering findings across studies to identify recurring factors related to collaborative improvement. These factors were then synthesised into higher-level themes that

described the conditions enabling collaborative improvement in inter-organisational contexts.

The analysis focused on four factors—shared goals, shared vision, shared interests, and trust—alongside organisational structures, processes, and systems that may enable and support collaborative improvement.

3.4.2 Study 2 (Paper B) – Collaborative Improvement in Rural Ecosystems (LUP Study)

The second study examined how co-creation and facilitation support improvement and innovation within a local development project in two rural Swedish villages. A multisite qualitative case study design (Creswell, 2014; Yin, 2014) was used to explore complex, socially grounded processes in their natural contexts. These projects were part of a municipality-supported, LEADER-funded initiative aimed at stimulating community-driven development. The two cases were selected to capture variation in rural development conditions, contrasting a context characterised by depopulation with one shaped by tourism-driven growth and in-migration. My prior knowledge of the local context informed the selection of these cases and contributed to an understanding of the different challenges encountered in the two villages. Both cases were in early phases of development, thus making them particularly suitable for examining how co-creative processes and collaborative improvement efforts emerge in practice.

Data collection for Study 2 (Paper B – LUP-study)

Data collection combined several qualitative methods:

- Twelve semi-structured interviews were conducted with stakeholders actively involved in the local development

projects, including representatives of local associations, entrepreneurs, and municipality-employed facilitators. Interviewees were purposively selected based on their active roles in the development projects. Initial participants were identified with the support of a municipality-employed facilitator, after which a snowball sampling approach was employed to recruit additional relevant actors. Eleven of the twelve interviews were conducted jointly by two researchers. Their different levels of familiarity with the research context provided complementary perspectives during the interviews. My local knowledge enabled me to ask more context-specific and relational follow-up questions, while the second researcher, who did not share the same local preunderstanding, approached the participants' accounts from a more external perspective.

- Participant observations were conducted during workshops and meetings, observing interactions, facilitation strategies, and how shared ideas developed over time. In the village where I was also a resident, my role was not limited to observation. When local engagement declined and some areas risked remaining unrepresented, I occasionally took a more active role in the development process. In these situations, the roles of researcher and local participant became intertwined.
- Document analysis was conducted on project plans, workshop materials, and communication outputs.

Data analysis for Study 2 (Paper B – LUP study)

The data analysis followed an iterative thematic approach (Creswell, 2014). I conducted an initial review of all transcribed interviews, after which the material was analysed jointly by the two researchers

involved in the data collection. The third co-author contributed to the later stages of the analysis and interpretation. Interview excerpts were compared and clustered using a shared digital whiteboard, which allowed emerging interpretations to be discussed from our different perspectives. Codes and categories were subsequently refined through comparisons across interviews, observations, and documents. The analysis identified two overarching categories: structure and process and engagement and motivation. Each category contained several interrelated factors, such as facilitation, credibility, trust, time, leadership, and commitment.

3.4.3 Study 3 (Paper C) – Inter-organisational experiential exchanges (SUB-study)

The third study explored how facilitation influences the way ideas are co-created and developed in an inter-organisational setting. It examined how ideas emerge, are shared, and evolve through facilitated experiential exchanges that connect actors across regional and organisational boundaries.

A qualitative, multi-case exploratory design was adopted (Stake, 1995; Yin, 2014), focusing on two peer-to-peer exchanges within a collaborative development initiative. These exchanges were part of the Sustainable Arctic and Peripheral Biking Tourism (SUB) project, a publicly funded initiative involving cycling tourism actors from several peripheral regions in five Northern European countries. The participants included entrepreneurs, facilitators, and destination actors representing activities such as guiding, equipment rental, trail development, and destination management. I participated in the exchanges in a dual role as both a cycling tourism entrepreneur and a researcher. Participating in the exchanges provided first-hand insights into the activities and interactions being studied, as well as

contextual understanding of the participants' professional settings. All participants were informed about my dual role.

Data collection study 3 (Paper C – SUB-study)

Data collection combined three complementary qualitative methods:

- Semi-structured interviews were conducted with entrepreneurs, facilitators, and project managers. The interviews also made it possible to follow up on situations that I had observed during the exchanges. For example, when one interviewee described another participant as taking on an informal facilitating role, I recognised the situations being referred to and could ask more specific follow-up questions. At other times, interviewees highlighted situations or interactions that I had not noticed myself, which added perspectives that extended beyond my own observations.
- Participant observations were conducted during workshops and informal interactions. Because my roles as participant and researcher were intertwined during the exchanges, I prioritised participation in the activities rather than continuous note-taking. Observations and reflections were therefore primarily documented after the activities, with occasional notes taken during activities when doing so did not interfere with my participation.
- Document analysis was conducted on project materials such as agendas and project plans.

Data analysis for Study 3 (Paper C – SUB-study)

The data analysis followed a reflexive thematic approach (Braun & Clarke, 2022). Themes were developed primarily inductively and

refined through comparisons across cases and data types. The analysis focused on how facilitation strategies, exchange design, and participant interaction influenced the emergence and development of ideas, as well as how participants translated their shared experiences into context-specific practices.

3.5 Ethical considerations

Ethical considerations were integrated into every stage of the research process. Ethics was approached as a reflective and relational practice, consistent with Aluwihare-Samaranayake (2012) and Cannella and Lincoln (2017). Participants were informed about the purpose of each study, the voluntary nature of participation, and how the data would be used. Recordings were deleted after transcription, and identifying details were anonymised to protect confidentiality. This was particularly important given the relatively small and closely connected contexts involved in the studies, where participants could otherwise be identifiable. In some cases, quotations that could reveal participants' identities were omitted to safeguard anonymity.

In the empirical studies, ethical considerations were closely connected to my role in the field. In Paper B, my dual role as a community member and a researcher required continuous attention to power relations and representation (Dwyer & Buckle, 2009). Similarly, in Paper C, I participated in the same project network that I was studying, which required ongoing awareness of how my presence and involvement might influence interactions and interpretations. Ethical sensitivity was therefore important throughout the studies, particularly in considering whose voices were emphasised or potentially overlooked (Aluwihare-Samaranayake, 2012). In addition, involving co-authors and

supervisors in the interpretation process provided an external perspective on the empirical material, thus helping to mitigate potential bias related to the researcher's dual role.

Ethics was not treated as a separate procedural requirement but rather as an ongoing and situated process. In line with Cannella and Lincoln (2017), ethical considerations involved continuous reflection on relationships, responsibilities, and the potential consequences of the research for participants and their contexts. This approach emphasised respect for participants and the aim of producing knowledge that is both responsible and relevant to the settings studied.

3.6 Quality criteria - Rigour, trustworthiness and Reflexivity

Rigour in this research was supported through methodological transparency, reflexivity, and triangulation across data sources (Denzin & Lincoln, 2011). Collaboration with co-authors and supervisors also played an important role in strengthening the rigour of the research, as interpretations and analytical decisions were continuously discussed and critically examined. Following Lincoln and Guba's (1985) criteria for trustworthiness, this research was designed to support credibility, transferability, dependability, and confirmability.

Throughout the research process, reflexivity was maintained as an ongoing methodological practice, understood as the continuous critical examination of how the researcher's assumptions, position, and involvement influence the research process (Braun & Clarke, 2022; Finlay, 2002). A reflexive journal was used throughout the empirical studies, which included notes that were taken during or

after workshops and exchanges, and before and after interviews. These notes included observations and emerging interpretations, as well as reflections on my own role, my relationships with participants, and interactions between participants. The journal developed from a set of relatively unstructured notes into a more systematic practice as the research progressed. It provided a way to return to earlier observations and assumptions during data collection and analysis and to consider how my own involvement may have shaped what I noticed and how I interpreted those observations (Aluwihare-Samaranayake, 2012; Finlay, 2002).

As the three studies differ in design and empirical context, the strategies used to ensure quality also vary and are outlined below.

3.6.1 Quality criteria for Study 1 (Paper A): Systematic Literature Review

In Study 1, rigour was ensured through the implementation of a structured and transparent review process. In line with established methodologies for systematic literature reviews (Denyer & Tranfield, 2009; Tranfield et al., 2003), clear inclusion criteria, search strategies, and selection procedures were applied. The use of multiple databases and complementary search tracks strengthened the exhaustiveness of the review.

Credibility and dependability were supported through the systematic screening, coding, and clustering of the articles, ensuring that the findings of this review were derived consistently from the selected material. Transparency in the review process, including documentation of search and selection steps, helped ensure confirmability (Denyer & Tranfield, 2009; Tranfield et al., 2003).

The analysis was conducted in collaboration with co-authors, thus allowing different interpretations and categorisations to be discussed and refined, which strengthened the consistency and credibility of the findings.

3.6.2 Quality criteria for Study 2 (Paper B): Collaborative improvement in rural ecosystems (LUP-study)

In Study 2, credibility was strengthened through methodological triangulation, combining interviews, observations, and document analysis (Denzin & Lincoln, 2011). This approach offered a more comprehensive understanding of co-creation processes in context. The use of rich descriptions of the empirical setting supported transferability by allowing readers to assess the applicability of findings of this study to similar contexts (Tracy, 2010).

Dependability was supported through iterative coding and continuous comparison across the empirical material. Interpretations were discussed between the two researchers involved in data collection, with the third co-author contributing to later stages of the analysis and interpretation. This allowed additional perspectives to be incorporated into the analytical process. This was particularly important given my position as both a researcher and a community member in one of the cases. The second researcher involved in data collection did not share the same local pre-understanding and therefore provided a different perspective on both data collection and analysis. In combination with the reflexive journal, these discussions helped make my own assumptions and interpretations more visible and open to critical examination (Dwyer & Buckle, 2009; Finlay, 2002).

3.6.3 Quality criteria for Study 3 (Paper C): Inter-organisational experiential exchanges (SUB-study)

In Study 3, credibility was supported through the combination of interviews, participant observations, and document analysis (Denzin & Lincoln, 2011), as well as through close engagement with interaction processes in the empirical setting under investigation. The multi-case design of this study, focusing on two exchanges, enabled comparison of interaction processes across different exchange settings.

Reflexivity was particularly central in this study due to my intertwined roles as participant and researcher. The reflexive journal was used to document observations and reflections after exchanges, workshops, and interviews, including reflections on my own involvement, my relationships with participants, and interactions between participants. These notes provided a way to revisit situations and emerging interpretations during the research process and to consider my own observations alongside participants' accounts. Ongoing discussions with my supervisors provided additional perspectives and opportunities to question emerging interpretations (Dwyer & Buckle, 2009; Finlay, 2002). These practices supported confirmability by making my own position and assumptions more visible during the analytical process.

Dependability was supported through the systematic documentation of the coding and analysis process and through iterative comparison across data sources and cases.

4 Summary of appended papers

This chapter presents a summary of the appended papers and my contributions to each paper. The full papers are presented in the appendix.

Table 2. Overview of appended papers and my contributions

	Paper A	**Paper B**	**Paper C**
Author (year)	Östberg, L. & Eriksson, M. (2023)	Östberg, L., Snyder, K. & Lilja, J. (2025)	Östberg, L. (2026)
Title	Collaborative improvement as a driver for excellence - findings from a systematic literature review	Key Factors Driving the Co-Creation of Collaborative Improvement and Innovation in Rural Development Ecosystems	Ideas in the Making: Advancing Open-TQM by Understanding the Role of Facilitation in Inter-organisational Improvement
Purpose	The purpose of this paper is to explore how collaborative improvement can be a driver of excellence for organisations that work together in inter-organisational systems.	The purpose of this article is to investigate the key factors that stimulate co-creation in collaborative improvement initiatives within rural development ecosystems.	The purpose of this study is to contribute to QM research by advancing the understanding of how improvement capability develops in inter-organisational settings, by conceptualising facilitation as a mechanism that enables such capability across organisational boundaries.
Methodology	A systematic literature review	A qualitative case study	A qualitative case study
My contribution	Led the systematic literature review, including data collection, analysis, and manuscript writing.	Led data collection and interviews, conducted participant observation, and was primarily responsible for analysis and manuscript writing, in collaboration with co-authors.	Single author

4.1 Summary of Paper A

Östberg, L. & Eriksson, M. (2023). Collaborative improvement as a driver for excellence – findings from a systematic literature review. 26th Excellence in Services International Conference (31 August – 1 September 2023, University of West Scotland, Paisley): Conference Proceedings.

Background

Collaborative improvement has become increasingly important as organisations operate in environments characterised by interdependence, global competition and shifting demands. Organisations rely on suppliers, customers and other stakeholders, thus increasing the need for joint improvement and innovation (Chesbrough et al., 2006; Chiu & Lin, 2022; Dodgson, 2014).

Continuous improvement is a key feature of high-performing organisations (Yearout, 1996) and is often linked to business excellence (Al-Khawaldeh & Sloan, 2007; de Leede & Looise, 1999). However, it has traditionally been studied within organisational boundaries, where priorities and resources can be controlled. In contrast, contemporary organisations operate in networks, where improvement depends on collaboration across boundaries (Camisón & Villar López, 2010; Kuhl & Costa, 2019).

Research shows that such collaborative improvement often develops in an ad hoc and unstructured manner (Middel et al., 2006; Middel et al., 2005), and our understanding of how continuous improvement unfolds in inter-organisational systems, particularly in loosely connected networks, remains limited (Zacharia et al., 2019). This

paper addresses this gap by focusing on the conditions that enable organisations to improve together.

Purpose and research questions

The purpose of this paper was to explore how collaborative improvement can act as a driver of excellence in inter-organisational systems. The study addressed the following research questions:

R1: What factors are involved in successful collaborative improvement?
R2: Which organisational structures, processes or systems enable and support collaborative improvement?

Methodology

A systematic literature review was conducted following established SLR methodology developed by Denyer and Tranfield (2009) and Tranfield et al. (2003), using CIMO logic to structure the analysis.

Searches were conducted in four databases: Business Source Complete, Emerald, Scopus and Web of Science. The review included peer-reviewed articles published in English between 2011 and May 2023 focusing on continuous improvement in inter-organisational contexts. Two search tracks were used to capture both the term "collaborative improvement" and related concepts. Following the screening process and the removal of duplicates, 21 articles were retained. A snowball search (Gough et al., 2012) added seven additional articles, resulting in a final sample of 28 articles.

These articles were analysed through a structured synthesis process involving coding and clustering of findings to identify recurring factors related to collaborative improvement.

Main findings

The review identified four key factors that are central to successful collaborative improvement:

- Shared goals
- Shared vision
- Shared interests
- Trust

These factors are well established in the research on continuous improvement in single organisations (Al-Khawaldeh & Sloan, 2007; Robinson, 1991; Shingo, 1988) and were also found to be important in inter-organisational contexts.

Shared goals provide direction and coordination, shared vision supports long-term commitment, and shared interests motivate joint problem solving. Trust emerged as a foundational factor, enabling dialogue, knowledge sharing and innovation, while lack of trust hindered improvement efforts.

In addition, organisational structures, processes and systems such as communication routines and coordination mechanisms support collaboration. These relational and structural conditions enable collaborative improvement and contribute to enhanced performance across inter-organisational systems.

4.2 Summary of Paper B

Östberg, L., Snyder, K., & Lilja, J. (2025). Key Factors Driving the Co-Creation of Collaborative Improvement and Innovation in Rural Development Ecosystems. *Journal of Service Theory and Practice,* 36(7), 24-45. https://doi.org/10.1108/JSTP-05-2025-0177

Background

Rural development contexts are increasingly shaped by complex challenges such as demographic change, resource constraints and reduced public services, which create a need for collaborative approaches to improvement and innovation (Anitha, 2024; Sharma et al., 2022). Ecosystem perspectives emphasise multi-actor collaboration, resource integration and co-creation across organisational boundaries as a way to address such challenges (Carida et al., 2022; Edvardsson et al., 2012).

Although continuous improvement has traditionally been studied within single organisations, ecosystem contexts require coordination among actors with different goals, resources and levels of authority (Chesbrough et al., 2006; Zacharia et al., 2019). Co-creation, rooted in service design, offers a way to structure these interactions through participatory processes and shared value creation (Jones, 2018; Trischler & Westman Trischler, 2022).

However, our understanding of how co-creation supports collaborative improvement and innovation in rural ecosystems is limited, particularly beyond short-term project settings. This paper addresses this gap by examining how co-creation develops and is sustained in practice

Purpose and research question

The purpose of the paper was to investigate the key factors that stimulate co-creation in collaborative improvement initiatives within rural development ecosystems.

RQ: What are the key factors that drive and sustain co-creation in rural development ecosystems to support collaboration and improvement?

Methodology

A multisite qualitative case study was conducted to explore co-creation in two contrasting rural development contexts in Sweden (Creswell, 2014; Yin, 2014). The cases represented different local conditions, one characterised by depopulation and one by growth through tourism and in-migration, within municipality-supported, LEADER-funded initiatives.

The local development processes brought together different types of actors, including local residents, representatives of local associations, entrepreneurs, and municipality-employed facilitators. Twelve stakeholders who were actively involved in the projects were interviewed. The data also included participant observations of development workshops and meetings and analysis of project-related documents.

The material was analysed using an iterative thematic approach, where patterns were identified across data sources through coding and comparison. This process resulted in the development of two overarching categories capturing the conditions enabling co-creation.

Main findings

The analysis identified two interrelated categories that enable co-creation in rural development ecosystems:

- Structure and process
- Engagement and motivation

Structure and process provide important conditions for collaboration through factors such as facilitation, credibility, time, frameworks and resources. Facilitation was particularly important in creating direction and maintaining momentum.

Engagement and motivation capture the human drivers of participation, including trust, leadership, personal commitment, external threats and a sense of impact. Participation was largely voluntary and driven by intrinsic motivation, with early successes reinforcing continued engagement. The contrasting local conditions also influenced how engagement was mobilised. In the depopulating community, the recurring threat of school closure created a sense of urgency and helped unite participants around a shared concern. In the tourism-driven community, where no equivalent acute threat was present and interests were more fragmented, engagement relied more on relationship building and facilitation. This illustrates how the factors enabling co-creation were shaped by the specific challenges and conditions of each local context.

Co-creation emerges from the interplay between structure and motivation. Although structure provides direction, sustained collaboration depends on trust and ongoing engagement, highlighting the need to move beyond project-based approaches towards continuous co-creation.

4.3 Summary of Paper C

Östberg, L. (2026). Ideas in the Making: Advancing Open-TQM by Understanding the Role of Facilitation in Inter-Organisational Improvement.

Background

Organisations increasingly operate in interdependent environments where improvement extends beyond organisational boundaries (Granstrand & Holgersson, 2020; Vargo & Lusch, 2016). Although QM has evolved from internally focused control towards continuous improvement and organisational learning (Bessant & Francis, 1999; Dahlgaard-Park et al., 2018), Open-TQM further emphasises that improvement capability develops through interaction across organisations (Dezi et al., 2025).

Although inter-organisational collaboration is assumed to support learning and improvement, our understanding of how improvement ideas actually emerge in such interactions remains limited. This limitation is particularly relevant in loosely structured inter-organisational contexts, where organisations rely on shared experiences rather than formalised improvement systems. This paper addresses this gap by examining how improvement ideas develop through inter-organisational experiential exchanges and how facilitation shapes these processes.

Purpose and research questions

The purpose of the paper is to advance understanding of how improvement capability develops in inter-organisational settings by examining idea development and the role of facilitation in this context.

RQ1: How do improvement ideas emerge and develop in inter-organisational experiential exchanges?
RQ2: How does facilitation shape improvement capability across organisational boundaries?

Methodology

The study adopts a qualitative case study design (Yin, 2014), focusing on two facilitated experiential exchanges within the Sustainable Arctic and Peripheral Biking Tourism (SUB) project. The project connects small tourism actors from several peripheral regions, and the exchanges bring together entrepreneurs, facilitators, and destination actors to share their experiences and reflect on practices across organisational and regional boundaries. This provides a relevant setting for examining how ideas emerge and develop across organisational boundaries.

Data were collected through semi-structured interviews, participant observations, and document analysis. The material was analysed using a reflexive thematic approach (Braun & Clarke, 2022), combining inductive coding with iterative interpretation across data sources. The researcher's dual role as both participant and researcher provided close access to interaction processes while requiring ongoing reflexive analysis.

Main findings

The findings show that improvement ideas do not arise from exposure alone but rather develop through interaction. Idea development follows a recurring pattern in which participants encounter practices, engage in dialogue, and reflect on how these practices can be adapted to their own context. The resulting ideas are

typically incremental rather than radical and emerge through interpretation and adaptation rather than through direct transfer.

Facilitation plays a key role in making these processes. When facilitation is limited, interaction remains uneven and depends on individual initiative. When facilitation is more structured, participants engage more consistently in dialogue, leading to deeper reflection and more frequent idea development.

Overall, the study shows that collaboration alone is insufficient to ensure improvement. Instead, facilitation shapes the conditions under which interaction, learning and improvement capability can emerge, positioning it as a key mechanism in inter-organisational improvement processes.

5 Main findings

This chapter presents the main findings of the thesis by synthesising the results from the three included papers in relation to the research questions. Rather than repeating the findings of each paper, which are summarised in Chapter 4, the focus here is on what can be learned by considering the findings across the studies. These papers contribute in different ways to addressing the research questions. Paper A provides a broader understanding of the factors that enable collaborative improvement, while Papers B and C show how collaborative improvement, idea development, and facilitation take shape in practice. Looking across the findings makes it possible to identify recurring patterns, differences, and complementary findings. The findings are presented thematically. An in-depth interpretation and theoretical discussion of these findings is provided in the discussion chapter following this chapter.

5.1 Findings related to Research Question 1

RQ1: What factors enable collaborative improvement across organisational boundaries?

The findings from these three papers suggest that collaborative improvement across organisational boundaries does not happen on its own. Instead, successful collaborative improvement depends on a number of conditions that enable interaction among organisations. These conditions concern relationships among actors, how collaboration is organised, and what motivates participation.

The first aspect concerns relationships among actors. Across the studies, trust appears as a recurring and foundational condition for collaboration. In the literature review (Paper A), trust is described as enabling dialogue and knowledge sharing, and as developing over

time in ways that support the co-creation of solutions. This is also evident in the empirical studies, where trust affects whether actors are willing to approach each other, share their experiences, and engage in joint activities. Alongside trust, the results from Paper A show that shared goals and, to some extent, shared interests help align actors and give direction to the collaboration, even when they come from different organisations.

A second aspect concerns the presence of structure and process. The findings show that collaboration benefits from some form of organisation, in which activities are planned and coordinated. In Paper A, this takes the form of organisational systems that support collaboration, while Paper B shows how structure and process provide legitimacy and direction in ecosystem settings. Within this context, facilitation stands out as a way of organising collaboration in practice. Across the empirical studies, facilitation is used to bring actors together, support how activities are carried out, and create opportunities for dialogue. When facilitation is limited, interaction tends to be uneven and depends more on individual initiative. When facilitation is more clearly organised, participation becomes more balanced and dialogue more consistent.

These findings also point to the importance of engagement and motivation. In Paper B, participation in collaborative activities is largely voluntary, and actors engage based on personal commitment, perceived relevance, and a sense of impact. This is supported by the literature reviewed in Paper A, in which working towards a shared purpose or joint commitment was described as an important driver of collaborative improvement. The literature also shows that how interaction is organised, for example through meetings or other forms of contact, affects how relationships develop and how willing actors

are to participate. External factors, such as shared challenges, can create an initial push for collaboration. Paper B illustrates how this drive was shaped by the local context. In one village, the recurring threat of school closure created a sense of urgency and mobilised actors around a shared concern, whereas in the other village, where interests were more fragmented and no equivalent acute threat existed, engagement relied more on relationship building and facilitation. These findings suggest that the relative importance of different enabling factors may vary depending on the challenges and conditions of the collaborative context. This point is also reflected in Paper C, where engagement varies depending on how interaction is structured. When opportunities for interaction are limited, participation becomes uneven and relies more on individual effort.

These findings suggest that collaborative improvement depends on how these conditions are combined in practice. Trust and shared direction support relationships, structure and process shape how interaction takes place, and motivation influences whether actors choose to take part and remain involved. When these elements come together in practice, organisations are better able to engage in improvement work that extends beyond their own boundaries.

5.2 Findings related to Research Question 2

RQ2: How does collaboration across organisational boundaries support the generation and development of ideas?

The empirical material shows that collaboration across organisational boundaries supports the generation and development of ideas by bringing actors into contact with one another. Ideas do not emerge in isolation, but rather develop through shared activities in which

participants meet, exchange experiences, interact, and reflect on their own practices in relation to others.

A central element in this process is co-creation, through which different actors contribute their own perspectives, knowledge, and experiences. In Paper B, workshops and other development processes bring together actors from different parts of the ecosystem. In these settings, ideas are shaped through discussion, comparison, and the combination of different viewpoints.

Findings from Paper C provide a more detailed picture of how this process unfolds in practice. Ideas are not generated simply by observing what others do. Instead, participants encounter practices in other organisations and then discuss and reflect on how these practices relate to their own context. Ideas are gradually formed and adjusted through interaction and reflection on others' practices, rather than being transferred directly.

Accordingly, idea development is closely connected to dialogue and reflection. Conversations and shared experiences give participants the opportunity to interpret what they observe and consider how it might be used in their own organisations. The ideas that emerge are typically incremental, and they often involve small changes to existing ways of working rather than entirely new solutions.

Collaboration across organisational boundaries supports idea generation and development by creating opportunities for interaction, dialogue, and reflection. Ideas are interpreted and adapted through these interactions and can contribute to continuous improvement.

5.3 Findings related to Research Question 3

RQ3: How does facilitation influence the generation and development of ideas across organisational boundaries?

As shown in Section 5.1, facilitation emerged as a recurring and important element in enabling collaborative improvement across organisational boundaries. The findings related to RQ1 highlighted facilitation as a way of organising collaboration in practice. This observation led to a more focused examination of facilitation, thereby contributing to the formulation of the third research question.

The empirical studies show that facilitation influences how ideas are generated and developed by shaping the way actors interact. Facilitation affects the conditions under which participants engage with one another and reflect on their experiences.

Facilitation is closely connected to how collaborative activities are organised. In Paper B, facilitation appears as part of the structure that supports collaboration, for example by providing direction, maintaining momentum, and bringing actors together. In Paper C, this becomes more visible in practice, as facilitation influences how participants interact during shared activities.

A clear pattern that emerges is that the level of interaction changes depending on how facilitation is carried out. When facilitation is limited, participants tend to remain within familiar groups, and conversations rely on individual initiative. In these situations, some participants take on informal leadership roles by initiating discussions, asking questions, or connecting others. While this can support interaction, it can also lead to uneven participation. When facilitation is more active, participants are more consistently drawn

into dialogue with others, creating more opportunities for them to compare experiences and reflect on what they observe.

Facilitation also affects how ideas develop over time. By structuring activities and encouraging interaction, it supports the kinds of conversations that lead to new insights. In more structured settings, participants engage more frequently in discussions that help move ideas forward. In contrast, when this structure is missing, learning tends to remain more individual and less developed.

Given the results from the studies, facilitation does not seem to determine the content of ideas. Instead, it helps create the conditions in which participants can interpret and adapt what they encounter. The role of facilitation in this context is therefore less about directing outcomes and more about supporting the process through which ideas take shape.

These findings point to facilitation as an important element in enabling idea development across organisational boundaries. By shaping interaction and creating space for dialogue and reflection, it supports the processes through which ideas emerge and develop in collaborative settings.

6 Discussion

At an overall level, the findings in this thesis contribute to a more process-oriented and relational understanding of how collaborative improvement and innovation emerge in inter-organisational contexts. Joint consideration of the three studies can improve our understanding of how collaborative improvement develops in practice. The findings show how the factors identified in these studies are connected and develop through interaction. They also show how facilitation supports the interaction through which relationships and ideas develop across organisational boundaries. Several of these findings cut across the three research questions.

The Discussion is therefore organised around these interconnected contributions rather than strictly following each individual research question. It begins with a broader discussion of collaborative improvement beyond organisational boundaries, followed by a more focused discussion of the mechanisms and processes that enable collaboration, idea development, and collective learning across organisational boundaries. The chapter also includes reflections on practical implications, followed by a methodological discussion.

6.1 Moving continuous improvement beyond organisational boundaries

Continuous improvement has primarily been studied and applied within the boundaries of single organisations, where improvement work is integrated into everyday practices and carried out through established and systematic approaches (Bessant et al., 2001; Jurburg et al., 2017). In such settings, organisations retain control over their priorities, resource allocation, and the organisation of improvement

processes (Farris et al., 2008). Much less attention has been given to the question of how improvement takes place across organisational boundaries, in which multiple actors need to coordinate their efforts without relying on a shared organisational structure.

The empirical studies presented in this thesis illustrate this complexity in different ways. In the rural development study, local actors, including entrepreneurs, representatives of community organisations, and municipality-employed facilitators, collaborated without belonging to a shared organisational structure. In the experiential exchanges, entrepreneurs and other actors from different organisations and geographical contexts met temporarily to exchange experiences and develop ideas. In both settings, the participating actors were organisationally autonomous, and no single actor controlled the overall improvement process. The rural context in Paper B also made the interdependence among actors particularly visible. Limited resources and distributed responsibilities meant that local development depended on contributions from actors who played different roles and had different interests. Addressing local development challenges therefore required coordination across organisational and community boundaries.

The absence of shared organisational structures and central control affects how collaborative improvement can be organised and carried out. Improvement may be initiated within individual organisations, but developing ideas across organisational boundaries requires interaction and coordination among actors. Research on ecosystems and collaborative governance has similarly highlighted the importance of interaction and resource integration across organisational boundaries for collective value creation (Bryson et al., 2021; Edvardsson et al., 2012; Vargo & Lusch, 2016). From an

ecosystem perspective, this shifts attention from the improvement capability of individual organisations towards how resources, knowledge, and improvement efforts can be connected across a wider system (Adner, 2016; Jacobides et al., 2018).

Previous studies have identified factors such as trust, shared goals, and organisational structures as important for inter-organisational collaboration (Kożuch & Sienkiewicz-Małyjurek, 2016; Mervyn et al., 2019). These factors were also present across the studies in this thesis. The findings, however, suggest that such factors should not be understood only as conditions that must be in place before collaboration begins. A shared direction developed as actors interacted and identified common interests, whereas trust was strengthened through repeated interactions and experiences of working together. The findings therefore suggest that collaborative improvement can be understood as an emergent and interaction-driven process in which some of the corresponding enabling conditions are also shaped by the collaboration itself.

Across the empirical studies, collaborative improvement was shaped by the interplay between structural conditions and human dynamics. Elements such as facilitation, frameworks, and resources provided direction and legitimacy and supported collaboration (Torfing et al., 2019; Vink et al., 2020). Their influence, however, depended on how actors engaged with and used them. Engagement, motivation, and trust affected whether collaborative activities were sustained, while external pressures could mobilise actors around shared concerns. Structures therefore provided conditions that could facilitate collaboration but did not determine how the collaborative process itself developed.

Paper C further shows that collaboration in itself does not lead to improvement. Improvement ideas do not transfer directly between actors but need to be interpreted and adapted to suit local contexts (Argote & Miron-Spektor, 2011). The findings of this study demonstrate how ideas were developed through interaction, as participants discussed, compared, and reflected on practices in relation to their own work rather than being directly transferred or implemented through predefined processes. These findings are consistent with perspectives that view learning as a social process shaped through participation (Wenger, 1998), as well as with research on psychological safety, which emphasises the importance of conditions that allow open dialogue (Edmondson, 1999, 2018). These findings extend these perspectives by showing that interaction across organisational boundaries does more than expose actors to new ideas; it provides opportunities for ideas to be interpreted and adapted in relation to different organisational contexts.

The findings also highlight the challenge of sustaining collaborative improvement over time. The empirical settings explored in this thesis were largely project-based and temporary, with collaboration and idea development connected to specific activities, exchanges, or externally funded initiatives. The findings show how these temporary collaborative settings created opportunities for engagement, interaction, and idea development across organisational boundaries, thereby supporting the initiation of collaborative improvement processes. At the same time, the studied initiatives did not establish long-term structures or routines for sustaining collaborative improvement beyond the duration of the projects. This thesis therefore contributes more directly to our understanding of how collaborative improvement emerges and develops across

organisational boundaries than to explaining how such improvement becomes institutionalised over the long term.

The combined findings in this thesis suggest that collaborative improvement develops through interaction across organisational boundaries. Unlike continuous improvement within a single organisation, collaborative improvement involves autonomous actors who do not operate within a shared organisational hierarchy or control structure. Collaborative improvement therefore depends on connecting knowledge, resources, and activities across organisational boundaries.

This is where the ecosystem perspective adds to our understanding of collaborative improvement. It shifts our attention from improvement capability as something located primarily within individual organisations towards the possibility that improvement capability is distributed across a wider system of interdependent actors. This perspective aligns with emerging discussions of Open-TQM, according to which improvement capability extends beyond the boundaries of single organisations and develops through interactions across ecosystems (Dezi et al., 2025). The findings in this thesis do not establish the existence of an ecosystem-level improvement capability, but they point to processes that may contribute to the development of such a capability, including repeated interaction, shared idea development, adaptation across contexts, and facilitated connections between actors.

6.2 Enabling collaborative improvement through emergent interaction

Research related to collaborative improvement is diverse and fragmented, drawing on multiple fields and offering varying

perspectives on how inter-organisational collaboration and improvement are enabled. These perspectives often emphasise factors such as trust, shared goals, and organisational structures. However, such factors have frequently been treated as conditions that can be established in advance, rather than as elements that develop through the collaborative process itself.

The findings in this thesis extend this view by demonstrating that enabling collaborative improvement is better understood as an emergent process in which these elements are continuously shaped through interaction. This perspective aligns with research that conceptualises learning and collaboration as socially constructed and as evolving through participation (Edmondson, 1999; Wenger, 1998), rather than as outcomes of predefined systems.

A central dynamic in this process is the relationship between structure and engagement. Previous research highlights the importance of frameworks and institutional arrangements in supporting collaboration (Torfing et al., 2019; Vink et al., 2020). The findings here show that such structures do not generate collaboration on their own. Their role is to support interaction. When aligned with participants' needs, they enable engagement, which in turn creates momentum as actors become more involved over time. This characterisation reflects views of continuous improvement as a capability that develops through repeated participation rather than through the implementation of fixed systems (Bessant et al., 2001; Jurburg et al., 2017).

Enabling collaborative improvement can therefore be understood as an ongoing balancing process, in which structures are adjusted in relation to the level and direction of engagement. The findings also

show that enabling factors such as shared direction do not necessarily exist from the outset. In Paper B, the recurring threat of school closure gave one community a shared concern around which actors could mobilise. In the other community, where there was no equivalent urgent driver, differing interests made it more difficult to establish a shared direction. These findings show how the conditions of the specific context can influence collaborative improvement, while a shared direction can also develop through interaction as the collaboration progresses.

The process is further characterised by iterative cycles of interaction, reflection, and adaptation. Consistent with research on organisational learning (Argote & Miron-Spektor, 2011; Edmondson, 1999), improvement ideas develop through dialogue in which practices are interpreted and adapted to local contexts. Sustaining such cycles is therefore central to enabling collaborative improvement. This finding calls into question the assumption that exposure to other actors or practices is sufficient for improvement to occur, highlighting instead the importance of maintaining conditions for continued interaction.

Serendipity adds another dimension to idea development. Unexpected encounters, observations, and interactions can lead to connections and ideas that were not anticipated in advance (Busch, 2024; Olshannikova et al., 2020; Roth, 2022). Although such ideas cannot be planned, collaborative settings can provide opportunities for unexpected connections to occur. Continued interaction can then allow actors to recognise, explore, and develop these ideas further.

The findings show that as these interactional processes continue, the functioning of the ecosystem may gradually shift over time. Collaboration becomes more generative, and ideas emerge across

actors and organisational boundaries. Communication and collaboration capabilities may also strengthen, making it easier to address both improvement-related and other shared challenges.

Enabling collaborative improvement thus involves continuous attention to the evolving dynamics of the ecosystem. Rather than designing fixed conditions, actors need to adapt structures and interactions in response to emerging needs. This thesis therefore contributes to a more process-oriented understanding of enabling, according to which collaboration develops through ongoing interaction rather than through fixed structures or predefined designs. Facilitation emerges as one important mechanism for shaping this interaction over time and is discussed in the following section.

6.3 Facilitation as a core mechanism of collaborative improvement

The findings of this research identify facilitation as a core mechanism through which collaborative improvement is enabled and sustained. Prior research has consistently highlighted facilitation as an important supporting condition for inter-organisational collaboration, often alongside factors such as trust, shared goals, and formal structures (Bryson et al., 2021; Torfing et al., 2019; Worley et al., 2022). However, while its importance is widely acknowledged, its role remains relatively underspecified, particularly in relation to how collaborative improvement works in practice.

Here, facilitation not only functions as structural support but also shapes how interaction unfolds over time. Rather than directing outcomes, facilitation shapes how actors engage with one another. This characterisation aligns with earlier conceptualisations of

facilitation as the organisation of dialogue and interaction (Worley et al., 2022), but extends this view by positioning facilitation as central to sustaining the iterative cycles of interaction, reflection, and adaptation described in Section 6.2.

This distinction also helps clarify the relationship between facilitation and leadership in collaborative settings. While previous studies have conceptualised leadership as encompassing multiple roles, including facilitation (Emerson et al., 2012; Sullivan et al., 2012), the findings in this thesis suggest that these concepts should not be treated as equivalent. In loosely structured inter-organisational settings, in which authority is distributed and participation is voluntary, leadership rooted in formal authority and direction is limited. Instead, the facilitative function becomes critical, as it helps support interaction and sustain engagement over time. In such contexts, collaboration cannot be mandated but must be continuously enacted through interaction, positioning facilitation not simply as one leadership role among others but as a central mechanism that can enable collaborative improvement.

The presence of facilitation is particularly important. Consistent with prior research suggesting that collaboration requires intentional support (Bryson et al., 2021; Torfing et al., 2019), the findings show that interaction tends to remain limited or fragmented in the absence of facilitation. Conversely, when facilitation is present, it helps sustain engagement, support inclusive dialogue, and enable participants to build on each other's ideas. This reinforces the view that collaborative improvement does not arise simply from bringing actors together but depends on mechanisms that actively support interaction over time.

Facilitation does not appear as a uniform or standardised practice. Rather, it may take both formal and informal forms, ranging from structured workshops and designated facilitators to more emergent roles taken on by participants themselves. Paper B also shows that the function of facilitation differed depending on the local context. In the community where the threat of school closure had already created strong motivation around a shared concern, facilitation helped structure and sustain collective action. In the other community, where interests were more fragmented, facilitation played a greater role in building trust, bridging different perspectives, and creating a foundation for collaboration. Facilitation can therefore be understood as an ongoing activity that takes different forms and serves different functions depending on the conditions of the collaboration. This characterisation is consistent with research emphasising adaptive and context-sensitive approaches to collaboration (Torfing et al., 2019).

While facilitation is generally discussed in positive terms in the literature, its role appears to be more complex. There are indications that facilitation may not always enable interaction in the intended way, particularly when it is misaligned with participants' needs or the dynamics of the group. Its effectiveness may therefore depend on how facilitation is aligned with the specific collaborative context. This aspect has received only limited attention in existing research and points to the need for further research on how different forms of facilitation influence collaborative processes and outcomes.

Overall, facilitation links structural conditions with the interactional processes through which collaborative improvement emerges. By supporting interaction, reflection, and sustained engagement over time, facilitation contributes to the ongoing coordination of improvement efforts across organisational boundaries.

6.4 Practical implications for collaborative improvement

The findings of this research have practical relevance for actors seeking to initiate, organise, facilitate, or participate in collaborative improvement across organisational boundaries. This includes facilitators and project leaders, managers and regional or local development actors, as well as entrepreneurs and other participants in collaborative networks and ecosystems. The implications of this research differ somewhat depending on the role these actors play in the collaborative process.

Across these roles, the findings suggest that collaborative improvement must be actively supported over time. Collaboration does not occur simply because the actors involved meet.

In practice, these findings have the following implications:

- For actors seeking to initiate and organise collaboration:

  Given that collaboration develops through ongoing interaction, actors seeking to initiate and organise collaboration need to be explicit about the purpose of each interaction. Shared goals or visions cannot be assumed to already exist within the ecosystem or network. Meetings and activities need a clear purpose, whether the intention is to explore ideas, align perspectives, or move processes forward. Space for dialogue, comparison of perspectives, and reflection is equally important. Too much structure can limit engagement, whereas too little structure may lead to unfocused discussions. Collaboration around improvement ideas is therefore more likely to develop through a

series of interactions over time than through a single workshop or meeting.

- For facilitators and others seeking to support idea development:

Facilitation should be used as a way of supporting interaction rather than as a set of predefined tools or methods. Facilitation involves ensuring that different voices are heard, helping participants connect perspectives, and supporting the development of ideas. Approaches also need to be adapted to the specific situation, as what works in one setting may not work in another. Ideas can rarely be transferred directly between actors; instead, they need to be discussed, interpreted, and adapted to suit local contexts. Supporting idea development therefore depends on ongoing interaction rather than isolated activities.

- For actors seeking to coordinate ecosystems and networks:

Actors seeking to coordinate ecosystems and networks need to work in an adaptive and responsive way. In ecosystems and networks, collaboration cannot be directed through authority alone, since participation is voluntary and engagement develops over time. Structures and interactions therefore need to be continuously adjusted as collaboration evolves. Sufficient structure is needed to support interaction while leaving space for participants to influence the process. This shifts the focus away from designing the "right" structures upfront and towards maintaining and developing interaction over time.

6.5 Methodological discussion

The research approach adopted in this thesis is closely linked to the research problem and has evolved over time. Reflection on the methodological choices made is therefore necessary, particularly in relation to how these choices may have shaped both the research process and the resulting findings.

A central aspect concerns the role of pre-understanding. The research was conducted over an extended period, during which both the empirical material and the researcher's understanding of the phenomenon developed iteratively. This is reflected in the evolution of the research questions, as findings on collaborative improvement led to facilitation emerging as a key aspect. The research design and data collection methods were also adjusted throughout the process. This flexibility enabled the study to follow emerging insights, but it also meant that the direction of the research was partly shaped by these evolving interpretations, which is consistent with reflexive qualitative approaches (Braun & Clarke, 2022).

This thesis combines different methodological approaches, including a systematic literature review and qualitative case studies. This approach allows collaborative improvement to be explored from multiple perspectives. Integrating findings across studies with different designs, data sources, and empirical contexts also creates challenges, particularly in terms of maintaining analytical coherence across studies with different starting points and assumptions. Such challenges are commonly associated with qualitative case study research that seeks to capture complex phenomena in context.

The systematic literature review was conducted early in the research process and reflects the knowledge and conceptual framing that was

available at that stage. Its scope was shaped by the concepts and research streams that were initially foregrounded, which may have influenced which studies were identified and included. In addition, practical constraints required the review to be delimited in terms of publication years. Despite these limitations, the review followed a structured and transparent process and provided an important foundation for the subsequent empirical work.

Another important aspect concerns the researcher's role and position. Parts of the empirical material were collected in contexts where the researcher had prior involvement. In Paper B, this involvement included living in one of the studied villages, and in Paper C, it included participating in the tourism context as both an entrepreneur and guide. Some interviewees were also known to the researcher. This position facilitated access and supported data collection, but it also raises questions related to bias and preconceptions. The researcher's familiarity with the context influenced both what was attended to and how situations were interpreted, which required ongoing reflexive consideration throughout the research process. This situation reflects the well-established tension between insider and outsider roles in qualitative research (Dwyer & Buckle, 2009), as well as the broader discussion of researchers taking mixed or engaged roles in practice-based research (Cronemyr & Huge-Brodin, 2024). To address this issue, the research was conducted in collaboration with co-authors, enabling continuous discussion and critical reflection on interpretations.

The choice of data collection methods also involves both opportunities and constraints. Interviews and observations enabled an in-depth understanding of the participants' experiences and interactions. Existing relationships between the researcher and

participants may have shaped the data by encouraging openness in some situations while limiting what was expressed in others. My dual role as participant and researcher created a methodological trade-off between proximity and analytical distance. Participation provided access to interactions and contextual understanding that would have been difficult to obtain otherwise, while also making it necessary to critically examine how my own involvement shaped what I noticed and interpreted.

Finally, the context of this study should be considered. The empirical work focuses on rural development ecosystems and specific collaborative settings. This limits the direct transferability of the findings to contexts with substantially different organisational and geographical conditions. The findings also show that factors such as engagement and facilitation may take different forms and serve different functions depending on the specific context. However, the purpose of the thesis is not statistical generalisation, but rather to contribute to a deeper understanding of collaborative improvement as a phenomenon. In line with qualitative research traditions, the findings presented here can therefore be understood as transferable to other settings in which organisations collaborate across boundaries (Lapan et al., 2012).

7 Conclusions

This chapter presents the conclusions of this thesis in relation to its three research questions. The conclusions are derived from the combined findings of the systematic literature review and the empirical studies and summarise the main contributions of this thesis regarding collaborative improvement and innovation across organisational boundaries.

7.1 RQ1: What factors enable collaborative improvement across organisational boundaries?

The literature review and empirical studies identify the following factors as important for enabling collaborative improvement across organisational boundaries:

- Facilitation that supports dialogue, interaction, and coordination among actors.
- Structures and processes that provide direction, legitimacy, and continuity for collaboration.
- Trust and relationship-building between participating actors.
- Shared direction and the perceived relevance of activities.
- Engagement and motivation among participants to contribute and remain involved over time.
- Time and opportunities to engage in repeated interaction and exchange.
- Access to resources, frameworks, and external support.

The findings also show that these factors are closely interconnected and difficult to separate from one another. Structures and facilitation

influence engagement, shared direction and trust, while engagement and trust affect how collaborative processes develop over time. Collaborative improvement therefore appears to emerge through the interaction between structural conditions and relational dynamics rather than through isolated enabling factors.

7.2 RQ2: How does collaboration across organisational boundaries support the generation and development of ideas?

The empirical studies show that collaboration across organisational boundaries supports the generation and development of ideas through the following mechanisms:

- Creating opportunities for actors to exchange experiences and perspectives.
- Enabling co-creation processes where ideas are jointly explored, adapted, and refined.
- Supporting peer-to-peer learning and reflection among actors from different contexts.
- Increasing exposure to new practices, approaches, and ways of thinking.
- Allowing ideas to develop iteratively through ongoing interaction and discussion.
- Creating social environments in which participants feel encouraged to share and test ideas.

The findings of this research demonstrate that ideas rarely develop as isolated individual outcomes. Rather, idea generation and development appear to emerge through interaction among actors. Collaboration across organisational boundaries not only supports the

sharing of existing knowledge but also contributes to the development and adaptation of ideas through co-creation.

7.3 RQ3: How does facilitation influence the generation and development of ideas across organisational boundaries?

The studies show that facilitation influences the generation and development of ideas across organisational boundaries in the following ways:

- By structuring and guiding interactions among participants through both formal and informal facilitation.
- By creating inclusive environments that support dialogue, participation, and relational trust.
- By supporting reflection, comparison of perspectives, and collective sense-making.
- By helping actors identify, connect, and adapt ideas to their own contexts.
- By sustaining interaction and engagement over time.
- By reducing barriers to communication and knowledge sharing among actors.

The findings further show that facilitation is not only a supportive activity surrounding collaboration but also an active mechanism that shapes how collaborative improvement and idea development unfold in practice. This includes both formal facilitation activities and more informal and emerging forms of facilitation, particularly in situations in which formal facilitation is limited or insufficient. The extent to which facilitation is present influences both the quality of collaboration and the conditions for co-creation across organisational boundaries. This thesis therefore contributes to a more relational and

interaction-oriented understanding of collaborative improvement across organisational boundaries.

7.4 Suggestions for future research

This thesis highlights several directions for future research concerning collaborative improvement and innovation across organisational boundaries. One such direction is to examine whether ecosystems themselves can develop improvement capabilities that extend beyond the capacities of individual organisations. Such research could challenge traditional QM assumptions that improvement capability resides within single organisations and instead explore how it emerges through collaborative processes spanning multiple actors and organisations.

A related question is whether ecosystems can develop shared idea infrastructures or distributed idea systems. Many organisations use formal systems to collect and manage ideas internally, yet far less is known about how ideas move and develop across organisational boundaries. Future research could examine how ideas emerge, develop, are implemented, or disappear in collaborative ecosystems; how ideas travel across actors and contexts; and whether ecosystems can retain and revisit ideas even when projects or collaborations end.

Future research could also focus less on isolated projects and more on how collaborative improvement develops over time. The empirical settings in this thesis were largely project-based and temporary, where collaboration and idea development were often connected to specific activities or funding periods. This raises questions regarding what happens when projects end and how collaboration around ideas, improvement, and innovation can be sustained over time.

Another area concerns power and exclusion in collaborative ideation processes. Ecosystems and co-creation have often been described as collaborative and inclusive, yet less attention has been paid to the questions of whose ideas become visible, whose perspectives dominate, and how certain understandings of improvement become prioritised over others. Future research could therefore examine how legitimacy, influence, and participation shape collaborative improvement in practice, particularly in loosely structured ecosystems or networks in which participation is voluntary and formal authority is limited.

Future research could also continue to explore facilitation as a mechanism that shapes collaborative interaction and idea development across organisational boundaries. More knowledge is needed regarding how facilitation shapes interaction and supports collaborative improvement over longer periods of time.

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